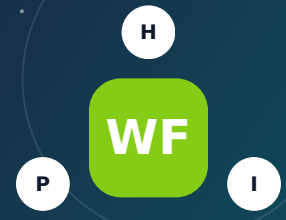


WILDFIRE HAZARD

Fire Hazard Severity Zone

Wildfire maps classify landscape hazard; a home's construction, defensible space, access, and ember resistance determine much of its actual risk.



1 Understand the factor

What it is - and why it matters

A Fire Hazard Severity Zone classifies areas based on factors such as vegetation, expected fire behavior, topography, climate, and ember exposure. It is a hazard designation, not a guarantee of loss and not always the same model an insurer uses.

Homes can ignite from wind-blown embers miles ahead of flames, from nearby vegetation or structures, from radiant heat, or from direct flame contact. Community access, water, power, and firefighting capacity also matter.

How risk can reach a household

- Wind-blown embers can enter vents, roofs, gutters, decks, fences, garages, and gaps around windows or siding.
- Radiant heat and direct flame can ignite vegetation, fences, outbuildings, vehicles, and the house itself.
- Smoke and PM2.5 can enter homes long before flames arrive and can affect regions far from the fire.
- Road congestion, power shutoffs, damaged communications, and limited water can complicate evacuation and suppression.

What people often miss

- A parcel outside the highest zone can still burn from embers or a neighboring structure.
- Roof, vent, deck, fence, eave, window, and landscaping details can dominate ignition risk.
- Private insurance models may use different boundaries, vegetation data, claims history, and access criteria than public maps.
- Post-fire slopes can create later debris-flow and flood hazards during storms.

? Five checks before buying

1

Check current state and local hazard maps, historical fire perimeters, evacuation zones, access, water, and hydrants.

2

Obtain the insurer's quote and inspection requirements before purchase; availability can change by address and carrier.

3

Inspect the roof, vents, siding, windows, decks, fences, outbuildings, vegetation, propane, and electrical service.

4

Determine whether the home meets current wildfire-building standards and whether mitigation documentation is available.

5

Drive evacuation routes during busy conditions and identify at least two options, including plans for pets and mobility needs.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION Map proximity is a screening signal - not proof of exposure, damage, or insurability. Confirm the exact feature, current condition, pathway, and property-specific controls.

HEALTH, PROPERTY AND COVERAGE

How this factor can affect a household

FACTOR 07

H Health impacts

- Wildfires can cause burns, traumatic injury, smoke inhalation, carbon monoxide exposure, and death.
- Evacuation, loss, uncertainty, and repeated fire seasons can cause anxiety, grief, sleep disruption, and post-traumatic stress.
- PM2.5 can worsen asthma and chronic lung disease and increase cardiovascular stress, especially in sensitive people.
- Power shutoffs and road closures can interrupt refrigeration, medical equipment, medications, and access to care.

P Property impacts

- Fire can destroy the dwelling, detached structures, utilities, landscaping, vehicles, contents, and neighborhood infrastructure.
- Reconstruction may face code upgrades, debris cleanup, contractor shortages, utility delays, and changed land-use requirements.
- Smoke, ash, heat, suppression water, and debris can damage a home even when it does not burn completely.
- Repeated fire exposure and insurance constraints can influence marketability, financing, maintenance costs, and community services.

I Insurance implications

- Wildfire risk can affect carrier availability, premium, deductible, inspection, mitigation requirements, and renewal decisions.
- A policy based on an outdated reconstruction estimate may leave a large gap after regional labor and material costs surge.
- Coverage details for smoke, trees, landscaping, debris, code upgrades, temporary housing, and guaranteed replacement cost vary.
- Separate flood coverage may be needed for post-fire flooding or debris-laden water because homeowners policies generally exclude flood.

Possible long-term health implications of buying nearby

- Repeated smoke seasons can create recurring respiratory and cardiovascular exposure even when the home is never directly threatened by flames.
- Children, pregnant people, older adults, outdoor workers, and people with heart or lung disease may be more vulnerable to smoke.
- Chronic preparedness, evacuations, insurance uncertainty, and fear of loss can affect sleep and mental health.
- Home hardening, clean indoor air, and evacuation planning can reduce risk, but no mitigation makes a wildfire-prone site risk-free.

Evidence lens

Evidence is strong for wildfire injury, smoke-related health effects, and the value of ignition-resistant construction and defensible space. Individual loss remains event- and site-specific.

Plan more carefully for

Children

Older adults

Pregnancy

Heart/lung conditions

Mobility or power needs

Insurance reality: Availability, eligibility, exclusions, deductibles, and limits vary by state, carrier, property, and cause of loss. Get an address-specific written quote before the purchase contingency expires.

PRACTICAL RISK REDUCTION

Precautions and a real-life example

FACTOR 07

V Verify the actual risk

- Confirm the current public zone, insurer classification, recent fires, evacuation routes, water supply, and local inspection rules.
- Keep home-hardening permits, defensible-space inspections, photos, receipts, and certifications for insurers and buyers.

P Protect the property

- Use a Class A roof, ember-resistant vents, maintained gutters, enclosed eaves, tempered windows, and ignition-resistant details.
- Create and maintain defensible space; separate combustible fences, mulch, furniture, sheds, and vegetation from the house.

M Monitor and respond

- Use official alerts, monitor wind and fire conditions, maintain N95 respirators and a clean-air room, and evacuate early.
- Keep vehicles fueled or charged, routes clear, medications packed, and household communication plans current.

I Prepare insurance records

- Recalculate reconstruction cost annually and review replacement-cost, code-upgrade, debris, and temporary-housing limits.
- Ask about mitigation credits, inspections, nonrenewal rules, deductibles, and backup coverage options.

REAL-LIFE EXAMPLE

2018 Camp Fire

November 8, 2018

The Camp Fire swept through Paradise and surrounding communities in Northern California. CAL FIRE reports 153,336 acres burned and more than 18,000 structures destroyed, with at least 85 fatalities. Extreme fire behavior, wind, embers, and evacuation challenges contributed to the catastrophe.

Why it matters: The event showed that community-scale ember exposure, road capacity, warning, vulnerable residents, and regional infrastructure can determine outcomes beyond an individual home's defensible space.

[Open official incident record - fire.ca.gov >](https://www.fire.ca.gov)

Questions to resolve before making a decision

1. Check current state and local hazard maps, historical fire perimeters, evacuation zones, access, water, and hydrants.
2. Obtain the insurer's quote and inspection requirements before purchase; availability can change by address and carrier.
3. Inspect the roof, vents, siding, windows, decks, fences, outbuildings, vegetation, propane, and electrical service.
4. Determine whether the home meets current wildfire-building standards and whether mitigation documentation is available.

Official sources and mapping tools

[CAL FIRE hazard severity zones - osfm.fire.ca.gov >](https://osfm.fire.ca.gov)[Ready for Wildfire - readyforwildfire.org >](https://readyforwildfire.org)[EPA wildfire smoke and health - epa.gov >](https://epa.gov)